plausible historical detail about Ashokan times. Using the threads that make up the tapestry of such legends, one may at least begin to understand the contexts and circumstances in which the man was born.

The strongest thread to emerge from the lore is that Ashoka's 'coming' as emperor of India was predicted. It was first predicted during one of Ashoka's own earlier lives. The 'prophet' who foretold it all was an ascetic. This is unsurprising: ancient India, much like modern India, was awash in holy men claiming clairvoyance. But this specific sage was not your average run-of-the-mill soothsayer: he was the greatest of all ancient ascetics, Gautama Buddha himself.[13] While the Buddha lived much of his life in the sixth century BCE whereas Ashoka, as the third emperor of the Maurya dynasty, belonged to the third, within sacred biographies of the Buddhist tradition chronological fluidity appears to have been fairly common.[14] Within this textual mode biographies, especially those depicting the Buddha, characteristically recount a past life before moving into a later rebirth or rebirths, or moving from the present to the past. In the instance at hand, a Buddhist emperor is incorporated into this tradition, making Ashoka a prediction subsequent to the Buddha. His coming, by being foretold by the Buddha himself, conjoins the two, making them seem inseparable from each other. Such insertion via legend of an earlier life of the king allows the introduction of a standard motif used in the ancient world—predisposing an audience to feel awed at the arrival of a regal saviour long awaited. Jesus was foretold, the Buddha was foretold, Moses was foretold. In those times it almost seems that if you hadn't been foretold you were not likely to be a sufficiently important religious figure or kingly personage. The telling of the story of the Buddha's prophecy about Ashoka's future arrival is an instance of adroit religious narration.

The story is first told in the *Ashokavadana*, which is a Sanskrit version of the life of Ashoka (in the form of a legend) written in the second century CE.[15] 'Avadana' means a noteworthy deed that shows the ways in which the